

Materia Medica III – Astringent Herbs (Stabilize & Bind)

Overview

Astringent herbs **bind, retain, and restrain leakage** of qi, blood, essence, and body fluids. They are used to **prevent further loss**, not to restore what is already depleted. Appropriate use requires confirmation that **pathogenic factors have been cleared**.

General Characteristics

Attribute	Description
Taste	Sour, astringent
Temperature	Varies
Channels	Lung, Heart, Liver, Kidney, Large Intestine
Core Actions	Restrain leakage; stabilize essence; stop discharge

Global Cautions

- **Do not use** when exterior pathogens, damp-heat, food stagnation, or excess heat are present.
 - Premature use may **trap pathogens**.
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Astringent Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Wu Wei Zi	Warm	LU, HT, KD	Stops cough; generates fluids; stabilizes essence; calms Shen
Wu Mei	Neutral	LU, SP, LV, LI	Generates fluids; binds Intestines; expels roundworms
He Zi	Neutral	LU, LI	Benefits voice; restrains Lung; stops diarrhea
Chi Shi Zhi	Warm	SP, ST, LI	Strongly binds Intestines; stops bleeding

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Rou Dou Kou	Warm	SP, ST, LI	Warms Middle Jiao; stops diarrhea; moves qi
Chun Gen Pi	Cold	LI, ST, LV	Clears damp-heat; binds Intestines; stops bleeding
Qian Shi	Neutral	SP, KD	Tonifies SP; stabilizes essence
Lian Zi	Neutral	HT, SP, KD	Tonifies SP & KD; calms Shen
Lian Xu	Neutral	HT, KD, SP	Tonifies SP, stops diarrhea
Shan Zhu Yu	Slightly warm	LV, KD	Stabilizes KD; tonifies yin
Jin Ying Zi	Neutral	KD, LI	Binds Intestines; treats prolapse
Sang Piao Xiao	Neutral	KD	Tonifies KD yang; stabilizes essence
Fu Pen Zi	Warm	KD, LV	Stabilizes KD; improves vision
Hai Piao Xiao	Warm	KD, ST	Stops bleeding; treats ulcers
Fu Xiao Mai	Cool	HT	Stops spontaneous & night sweating
Ma Huang Gen	Neutral	LU	Stops sweating
Lian Zi Xin	Cold	Bitter	Clears Heart Fire; Calms Shen

Wǔ Wèi Zǐ 五味子

Fructus Schisandrae Chinensis | *Schisandra fruit*

Nature & Flavor: Warm, Sour, Sweet

Channels: Lung, Heart, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Astringes Lung qi and stops cough/wheezing**

2. **Stabilizes and binds leakage of essence**
3. **Stops spontaneous and night sweating**
4. **Generates fluids and alleviates thirst**
5. **Calms the Shen**

Key Indications

- **Chronic cough/wheeze** from **LU ± KD deficiency** (esp. recurrent, weak voice/SOB, long course)
- **Spontaneous sweating/night sweats** (deficiency leakage)
- **Spermatorrhea, enuresis, urinary frequency** (KD instability)
- **Insomnia/palpitations** from **HT–KD disharmony** (deficient restraint)

Dosage

- **2–6 g** (decoction); **1–3 g** (powder)

Processing

- Typically used **unprocessed**; can be added later in decoction if you want to preserve aromatic/astringent effect.

Cautions/Contraindications

- **Do not use early in exterior conditions** or when pathogens remain (can **trap**)
- Avoid in **excess heat, damp-phlegm, Liver fire, or unresolved rash/heat toxin**

Exam Pearl

“All the leakages”: LU (cough) + sweat + essence/urine + Shen

Wū Méi 乌梅

Fructus Prunus Mume | *Mume fruit/Dark plum*

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Sour

Channels: Lung, Spleen, Liver, Large Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Astringes Lung and stops chronic cough**
2. **Binds intestines and stops chronic diarrhea**
3. **Generates fluids**
4. **Expels roundworms and alleviates pain**

Key Indications

- **Chronic diarrhea/dysentery** (more “**bind intestines**” than tonify)
- **Thirst/fluids damaged** (esp. chronic illness, deficiency heat patterns)
- **Chronic cough** with deficiency component (restrains LU qi)
- **Roundworm abdominal pain/vomiting** (classical: parasite pain with spasm)

Dosage

- **3–10 g**, up to **30 g** when needed

Processing

- **Charred (Tan)**: higher-yield for **bleeding/diarrhea** (astringency emphasized)

Cautions/Contraindications

- Not for **acute diarrhea** from **food poisoning/infection** or **marked stagnation/excess heat**
- Don’t “bind” if the pathogen/excess is still active

Exam Pearl

*Wu Mei is the **only astringent that expels parasites***

Hē Zǐ 诃子

Fructus Terminaliae Chebulae | *Chebula fruit/Myrobalan*

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Bitter, Sour, Astringent

Channels: Lung, Large Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Astringes/restrains Lung and benefits voice**
2. **Binds intestines and stops diarrhea**

Key Indications

- **Chronic cough/wheeze** with **voice loss/hoarseness** (restrains LU + benefits throat)
- **Chronic diarrhea/dysentery** (can be used in hot/cold depending on combo—test will cue)

Dosage

- **3–10 g**

Processing

- **Unroasted: benefits voice / clears LU**
- **Roasted: stops diarrhea** (stronger binding)

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid early-stage exterior patterns; don't bind before the pathogen is cleared.

Exam Pearl

- If the stem says “**chronic cough + lost voice**”, He Zi jumps to the top.
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Chì Shí Zhī 赤石脂

Halloysitum Rubrum | *Halloysite/kaolin*

Nature & Flavor: Warm, Sweet, Sour, Astringent

Channels: Spleen, Stomach, Large Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Strongly binds Intestines; stops diarrhea**
2. **Stops bleeding**
3. **Promotes healing of sores (topical)**

Key Indications

- **Chronic diarrhea/dysentery** (mucus ± blood) from deficiency/cold
- **Uterine bleeding**, blood in stool when “cold/deficiency containment failure” is emphasized
- **Topical:** promotes healing of chronic sores/ulcers

Dosage

- **10–20 g** (decoction or powders); topical powder as needed

Processing

- **Wrap in gauze** or **pre-decoct** (exam-friendly handling note from many teaching traditions)

Cautions/Contraindications

- **Pregnancy caution**
- Can **bind/adsorb** in GI tract → separate from medications by a couple of hours to prevent medication absorption issues

Exam Pearl

- **Strongest intestinal binder** (if question says “chronic, unremitting diarrhea” → Chi Shi Zhi).
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Ròu Dòu Kòu 肉豆蔻

Semen Myristicae fragrans | *Nutmeg*

Nature & Flavor: Warm, Acrid

Channels: Spleen, Stomach, Large Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Warms middle burner**
2. **Binds intestines and stops diarrhea**
3. **Moves qi and alleviates pain**

Key Indications

- **Chronic diarrhea** from **SP yang deficiency** (often with cold abdominal pain)
- **5 AM diarrhea** / “daybreak diarrhea” patterns when cold/yang deficiency is emphasized
- Diarrhea with **qi stagnation** signs: distention, fullness, poor appetite (warms + moves qi)

Dosage

- **3–10 g** decoction; **1.5–3 g** powder

Processing

- **Roasted is preferred/standard** for therapeutic use (warming + binding; reduces irritant effects)

Cautions/Contraindications

- **Fresh/unprocessed** can irritate intestines → may worsen diarrhea
- Avoid binding if diarrhea is from **active damp-heat/pathogen**

Exam Pearl

- **“Warm the middle + bind diarrhea”** (it’s not just a binder; it’s a **warming qi-regulating binder**).

Chūn Gēn Pí (Chun Pi) 椿根皮

Cortex Ailanthi altissima | *Ailanthus bark*

Nature & Flavor: Cold, Bitter, Astringent

Channels: Large Intestine, Stomach, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Clears damp-heat**
2. **Binds intestines and stops diarrhea**

3. **Stops uterine bleeding**
4. **Kills parasites (topical)**

Key Indications

- **Damp-heat diarrhea/dysentery** (often **blood/pus** in stool)
- **Uterine bleeding/leukorrhea** from damp-heat (astringe + clear)
- **Topical:** antiparasitic/antifungal itching patterns (depending on how you teach it)

Dosage

- **3–5 g** internally; **external wash/ointment** as needed

Processing

- Commonly decocted; external preparation as a wash.

Cautions/Contraindications

- Larger doses may cause **GI upset** (nausea/vomiting)—pair with appropriate herbs to keep dose moderate.

Exam Pearl

- The “**cold astringent**” for **damp-heat diarrhea** (bind + clear).

Lián Zǐ 蓮子

Semen Nelumbinis | *Lotus seed*

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Sweet, Astringent

Channels: Heart, Spleen, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies Spleen and stops diarrhea**
2. **Stabilizes Kidney and secures essence**
3. **Nourishes Heart and calms Shen**

Key Indications

- **SP deficiency diarrhea** (chronic, weak appetite/fatigue)
- **KD deficiency** with **spermatorrhea/leukorrhea** (stabilizes essence)
- **Insomnia/anxiety** where **HT-KD deficiency** is part of the pattern (calms Shen + binds)

Dosage

- **6–15 g**

Processing

- Commonly **decocted**; also food therapy.

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid with **dry constipation** / significant dryness

Exam Pearl

- The “**3-system binder-tonic**”: **SP (diarrhea) + KD (essence) + HT (Shen)**.
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Lián Xu 莲须

Nelumbinis Stamen | *Lotus stamen*

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Sweet, Astringent

Channels: Heart, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Stabilizes and binds essence**
2. **Stops uterine bleeding**
3. **Clears Heart and calms Shen**

Key Indications

- **KD instability:** spermatorrhea, frequent urination, leukorrhea (restrains leakage)
- **Excessive dreaming** / unsettled Shen from **HT-KD deficiency heat** (clears HT while astringing)
- **Bleeding** presentations where “astringe + stop bleeding” is emphasized in the stem/stamen group

Dosage

- Commonly taught ~**1.5–6 g** (decoction range).

Processing

- Typically unprocessed; some traditions use **charred** for bleeding (if you teach that variant).

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid in **constipation** / when binding would worsen retention.

Exam Pearl

- **More “pure astringent” than Lian Zi** (less tonic, more restraining).
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Shān Zhū Yú 山茱萸

Fructus Cornus officinalis | *Cornelian cherry fruit*

Nature & Flavor: Slightly warm, Sour

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Stabilizes and binds Kidney essence**
2. **Tonifies Liver and Kidney**
3. **Prevents collapse from excessive sweating**

Key Indications

- **KD leakage:** urinary frequency, incontinence, spermatorrhea (astringes KD)
- **Collapse tendencies** (classical: helps “secure” and prevent further loss)
- **LV/KD deficiency** with weakness of low back/knees + leakage picture

Dosage

- **5–10 g**, up to **30 g** in severe leakage

Processing

- Usually unprocessed.

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid with **difficult urination from damp-heat** / constrained heat in lower burner
- Use caution in **deficient KD fire** patterns (where warming/transforming is needed instead of binding)

Exam Pearl

- **Astringent + yin-tonic direction** (it “secures” while supporting LV/KD).
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Fu Xiao Mai 浮小麦

Triticum aestivum | *Floating wheat*

Nature & Flavor: Cool, Sweet

Channels: Heart

Primary Actions

1. **Stops spontaneous and night sweating**
2. **Clears deficiency heat**
3. **Relieves irritability**

Key Indications

- **Spontaneous sweating (Qi deficiency)** and **night sweats (Yin deficiency)**
- “**Steaming bone**” sensation from **Qi-Yin deficiency** with deficiency heat
- **Irritability/insomnia** when sweating is part of the deficiency picture

Dosage

- **15–30 g** (Fu Xiao Mai)
- (Some teaching traditions list **Xiao Mai** higher, **30–60 g**, when used food-therapy style)

Processing

- Usually used **unprocessed** in decoction (sometimes lightly dry-fried in practice, but not essential for exam answers)

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid when sweating is from **exterior pathogen** or **excess heat**

Exam Pearl

- Think “**deficiency sweating + irritability**” → Fu Xiao Mai.
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Ma Huang Gen 麻黄根

Ephedrae Radix | *Ephedra* root

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Sweet

Channels: Lung

Primary Actions

1. **Stops sweating from deficiency**

Key Indications

- **Stops sweating from deficiency** (classically spontaneous; can be used for night sweats in deficiency patterns)
- Used when the question is simply: “**stop sweating**” and you don’t need the HT-focused nuance of Fu Xiao Mai

Dosage

- **3–10 g**

Processing

- Typically **unprocessed** in decoction.

Cautions/Contraindications

- **Contraindicated in exterior conditions** (don’t trap pathogens by closing the pores)

Exam Pearl

- **Sweating-only stopper** (compare with **Fu Xiao Mai** = HT/Yin-def nuance).
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Qian Shi 芡实

Euryale ferox | *Euryale seed, Fox nut*

Nature & Flavor: Neutral, Sweet, Astringent

Channels: Kidney, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Strengthens Spleen and stops diarrhea**
2. **Stabilizes Kidney and binds essence**

Key Indications

- **SP deficiency with damp:** chronic diarrhea (esp. pediatric “damp diarrhea” pattern)
- **KD deficiency:** spermatorrhea, leukorrhea, urinary frequency (stabilizes essence)
- Often used when the stem says: “**tonifies SP + stabilizes KD**” but with a **damp** flavor (SP focus)

Dosage

- **10–15 g**

Processing

- Typically unprocessed in decoction.

Cautions/Contraindications

- Use caution if there is **significant constipation** (binding tendency).

Exam Pearl

- **Lian Zi vs Qian Shi:** Lian Zi has **HT/Shen** emphasis; **Qian Shi** has **damp/SP** emphasis.

Fu Pen Zi 覆盆子

Rubus chingii | *Chinese raspberry fruit*

Nature & Flavor: Slightly warm, Sweet, Astringent

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Stabilizes Kidney and secures essence**
2. **Reduces urinary frequency**
3. **Tonifies Liver and Kidney and improves vision**

Key Indications

- **KD deficiency leakage:** enuresis, urinary frequency, spermatorrhea, premature ejaculation
- **LV/KD deficiency vision issues** (blurred vision) + low back weakness
- Also shows up in “**diabetes insipidus-like polyuria**” presentations (KD not securing fluids)

Dosage

- **3–10 g**

Processing

- Often unprocessed; sometimes dry-fried in practice (not usually needed for exam answers).

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid where there is **yin deficiency fire/excess heat** driving symptoms (don’t just “bind”).

Exam Pearl

- **Secure KD + brighten eyes** (if they mention **vision**, it’s a big differentiator vs many other stabilizers).

Herbal Comparisons

- **Wu Wei Zi vs. Wu Mei:** All leakages vs. fluids & parasites
- **He Zi vs. Wu Wei Zi:** Voice/Lung vs. multi-system
- **Chi Shi Zhi:** Strongest intestinal binder

Structural Overview

Stop Cough:

- **Wu Wei Zi**
- **Wu Mei**
- **He Zi**

Stop Sweating:

- **Wu Wei Zi**
- **Fu Xiao Mai**
- **Ma Huang Gen**

Stabilize Essence:

- **Wu Wei Zi**
- **Shan Zhu Yu**
- **Lian Zi**

- **Qian Shi**
- **Fu Pen Zi**
- **Lian Xu**

Stop Diarrhea:

- **Wu Mei**
- **He Zi**
- **Qian Shi**
- **Lian Zi**
- **Rou Dou Kou**
- **Chi Shi Zhi**
- **Chun Gen Pi**

Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus-Bonus

Lián Zǐ Xīn 莲子心 (Herbs that Clear Heat/Drain Fire)

Nelumbinis Plumula | *Lotus seed embryo*

Nature & Flavor: Cold, Bitter

Channels: Heart, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Clears (sedates) Heart Fire / clears Heat from the Heart (± Pericardium)**
2. **Calms the Shen / tranquilizes**
3. **“Communicates” Heart and Kidneys / restores Heart–Kidney coordination**
4. **Stops bleeding by cooling Blood/clearing Blood-Heat**
5. **Astringes (secures) essence**

Key Indications

- High fever or lingering febrile Heat with **mental confusion, delirium, restlessness/irritability**.
- **Insomnia** from Heart Heat/Fire (often: vexation, inability to settle, possibly thirst).
- **Insomnia + seminal emission/spermatorrhea** framed as failure of Heart–Kidney “coordination/communication.”
- **Hematemesis** and **hemoptysis** (and classically other “heat in Blood” bleed presentations) when Heat forces Blood out of the vessels.
- **Tongue ulcerations/mouth sores** when Heart Fire flares upward

Dosage

- **1.5–6 g.**

Cautions/Contraindications

- **Avoid in constipation or abdominal masses**

Exam Pearl

- Think **Heart/Pericardium Fire** → **restlessness/insomnia/delirium**, plus a “secondary” board-style pairing of **Blood-Heat bleeding** and **spermatorrhea** from **Heart–Kidney disharmony**.